

Chicago urban historian Shermann "Dilla" Thomas is settling into his new role at the DuSable Museum after getting laid off by ComEd.



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Weighing environmental tradeoffs

Landing a data center is worth the ecological impact, Illinois towns say

By John Lippert
Chicago Tribune

The Minooka data center would take up to 340 acres, or slightly more than Chicago's Grant Park. It would need 3 million gallons of water a day. That's a third of all the drinkable water Minooka will be allowed to draw from a \$1.54 billion pipeline it's building with five other towns to access Lake Michigan water through Chicago. It would need a 700-megawatt supply of electricity, enough for half of Chicago's households. For Ric Offerman, Minooka's mayor, these are inescapable environmental tradeoffs to secure a

multibillion-dollar investment from Equinix Inc., a Redwood City, California-based company that operates 260 data centers in 33 countries. Offerman said Equinix could bring hundreds of permanent jobs to the village of 13,000 people 40 miles southwest of Chicago. It could bring in tens of millions in added tax dollars each year, even after an abatement the company is seeking. And unlike a proposed Canadian National Railway terminal nearby, Offerman said the data center wouldn't flood Minooka's central commercial district with hundreds of thousands of diesel trucks each

year. He's in court defending weight limits that keep trucks off the roads leading to downtown. Data centers give farm towns such as Minooka standing in the high-flying world of Equinix and its data center partners, which include Google Cloud, Microsoft Azure and Nvidia. But they're straining Minooka's effort to wean itself off underground aquifers that threaten to run dry and jeopardizing the state's bid to end the burning of fossil fuel in its power plants. The uncertainties are so great that, months after first proposing the data center to Minooka

Turn to Centers, Page 4



Ric Offerman, the mayor of Minooka, stands along Mondamin Road in town on Wednesday. Offerman said an Equinix data center could bring hundreds of permanent jobs to the village. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Once on the brink of closure, Dyett High School basks in winning its first basketball state championship



'WE'RE MAKING IT WORTH YOUR FIGHT'

By Rebecca Johnson | Chicago Tribune

Standing on a makeshift stage, a Dyett High School banner over his head, Jamaal Gill briefly paused his speech Friday as he looked out at the hundreds of cheering students celebrating the basketball team's state championship — the school's first. "It's been a wonderful season for us, but we couldn't have done it without you all — all the students, all the parents, teachers, staff," said Gill, the team's head coach, his voice cracking. "This is a collective effort, and I'm gonna cut this short because I'm a crybaby." "Let's make it a two-peat," a player called out over the cheers.

For the school and its surrounding neighborhoods of Washington Park and Bronzeville, though, victory has never been just about the trophy. Dyett's journey to becoming 2A state champion has the makings of a classic Cinderella story after the team defeated Belleville Althoff 52-41 at the University of Illinois' State Farm Center in Champaign on March 15. A decade ago, Chicago Public Schools had slated Dyett to close, when its last graduating class had only 13 seniors enrolled and gym classes were held online, years before the pandemic brought remote schooling into the zeitgeist. But after 12 people underwent a 34-day hunger strike in

2015, the pinnacle of a yearslong protest by community leaders determined to keep a neighborhood school, the district reversed its decision. The following year, Walter H. Dyett High School for the Arts opened its doors to about 150 freshmen. With this background in mind, the team's success has in some ways become a community celebration, and a testament to the school's resilience. "Their hard work kept us alive, gave us hope," said

Turn to Dyett, Page 6

Above: Ahmari Taylor holds the state championship trophy on Friday as Dyett High School's basketball team celebrates its win with a rally at the school in Chicago. AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Wisconsin race draws attention of billionaires

Musk, Pritzker among those spending in key Supreme Court election

By Dan Petrella
and Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

When the balance of power on Wisconsin's Supreme Court was on the line two years ago, the race smashed national spending records for state judicial elections and gave liberals a narrow majority after 15 years of conservative control. Although the state is divided politically, voters overwhelmingly backed a candidate who outwardly supported reproductive rights at a time when abortion services were on hold across Wisconsin due to the U.S. Supreme Court ruling that overturned federal protections. On April 1, the ideological makeup of Wisconsin's highest court is up for grabs once again — and again the state judicial race has become the most expensive in the nation as abortion remains a top animating issue in a state that went for Donald Trump in November while also reelecting Democratic U.S. Sen. Tammy Baldwin. But as Dane County Circuit Judge Susan Crawford faces conservative Waukesha County Circuit Judge Brad Schimel, one person's involvement is drawing as much attention as any issue: Elon Musk. Two groups funded by the world's richest man and polarizing Trump adviser have spent more than \$13 million in support of Schimel, the former state attorney general, according to a tally from the Brennan Center for Justice. Musk, who has taken his metaphorical chain saw to the federal government and lashed out at judges who've blocked the president's swift moves, is far from alone in funneling money from outside Wisconsin into an officially nonpartisan state Supreme Court election. Liberal financier George Soros has given \$1 million to the Wisconsin Democratic Party ahead of the April voting, and billionaire Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker — who previously signed a state law banning out-of-state campaign contributions to Illinois judicial candidates — gave the Wisconsin Democrats \$500,000 in January.

Turn to Wisconsin, Page 8

Illini rely on Boswell's defense

Kylan Boswell's defense and leadership key for Illinois as they look to slow Kentucky in second round of NCAA Tournament. **Chicago Sports**



Israel launches strikes on Lebanon

The retaliation for rockets targeting Israel marks the heaviest exchange in four-month truce with the militant group Hezbollah. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



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Complete forecast on Opinion, Page 12

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